In this he asked ‘if there is any room left for reconsideration’ because ‘popular opinion rightly or wrongly demands commutation’.

The letter is bizarre not only because it came far too late after his vacillations over the issue on 18 February and 19 March 1931, when he ended the discussion saying that he would leave the matter entirely in Irwin’s hands to decide as he would. It is bizarre also because while he reminds the viceroy for the first time how ‘political murders have been condoned before now’ and can be condoned now, he nevertheless does not make a complete uncompromising demand for release of the condemned in the Lahore Conspiracy Case. It is no good for anyone to say that Irwin would have remained unmoved at this late hour. How can we know? We cannot know that without a firm demand first for release being made. There was no solid demand. And yet, the expectation of the people of India during the prolonged negotiations with the British for the release of political prisoners was precisely that he be seen to at least be making a robust and unflinching demand of the viceroy of India that the Lahore conspirators also be released. If those languishing as political prisoners in India’s jails could be released on Gandhi’s demand, this was all the more reason that those condemned to die as political prisoners on the gallows should also be released on Gandhi’s demand. That was the expectation of the people. It did not happen. What we have is a muffled and muddled request from the Mahatma. The reason is that it was public opinion that the Mahatma was worried about. He was not making his own heartfelt demand of the viceroy. He was not imposing his own personal condition and saying that any agreement with Irwin will have to be subject to that condition. And Irwin knew that. Consequently, the Mahatma ended up taking the bite out of his request to Irwin. He made the request conditional. The condition was one over which the Mahatma himself had no control. He asked for ‘suspension of sentence *pending cessation of revolutionary murders*’ (emphases added).[19] How could Gandhi guarantee to Irwin that those whom he dismissed as ‘deluded patriots’ would stop the revolutionary struggle? If he could not, then what assurance did Irwin have from the young revolutionaries themselves that there would be an immediate cessation of